



METROPOLIS

Giant Cars Are Going Global

Countries need to fight back against SUVs and pickup trucks before it's too late.

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Like a disease, car bloat is spreading. The United States is patient zero: 4 out of 5 new cars in the U.S. are now SUVs or pickups, a sharp increase from a few decades ago. Now, oversized cars are becoming almost as common in Berlin and Beijing as they are in

Baltimore. SUVs alone comprised nearly half of car sales worldwide in 2023, up from 20 percent 15 years ago. The global ascent of giant cars is an ominous trend for climate change, as well as for road safety in the rich and developing worlds alike.

I use the term “car bloat” to describe the confluence of two trends that have transformed the U.S. automotive market. First, SUVs and pickups have supplanted standard sedans and station wagons, both of which the Big Three carmakers no longer offer to American consumers. Second, existing car models have steadily expanded in weight and size. The bestselling F-150 pickup, for instance, added 800 pounds, 7 inches of height, and 15 inches of length between 1991 and 2023.

Larger vehicles exacerbate an array of societal problems, starting with crashes. Taller cars have bigger blind spots and are more likely to strike a pedestrian’s head or torso instead of their legs. Heavier models can pulverize smaller ones, making traffic jams “an ethics class on wheels,” as the Economist recently put it. They also require more energy to move, making them more polluting, and they hasten the erosion of roads and tires.

The American origins of car bloat go back to the 1970s, when pickups and SUVs were niche products targeted toward off-roaders and those working in trades like construction. Recognizing an upsell opportunity, automakers began to market such models toward carbuyers who hauled nothing heavier than a child and went nowhere more adventurous than a shopping mall. Federal policy provided a critical tailwind, with Congress applying more lenient fuel economy rules toward the weightiest vehicles and offering tax credits to small-business owners who purchase them. As bigger vehicles caught on, the trend became self-reinforcing: Holdouts felt pressure to upsize simply to avoid being at a disadvantage on the road.

Until recently, car bloat might have been considered a distinctively American trend (or more accurately “North American,” since Canada’s auto market is inextricably connected to its southern neighbor). Expansive pickups have always been much more popular in the U.S. than in most other countries; they currently represent less than 1 percent of the European car market. SUVs have historically found more global buyers, but as recently as 2010, they comprised barely 10 percent of new car sales in Europe and only around 15 percent in China. That same year, the majority of car purchases in the U.S. were “light trucks” (SUVs and pickups plus a small number of vans).

A number of factors can explain why car bloat emerged first in the U.S. One is wealth: Bigger cars are more expensive to purchase and fuel, and comparatively affluent Americans could better afford them. Larger cars can be cumbersome to maneuver and park in dense urban areas, which are more common in Europe and Asia than in the U.S.

And, importantly, most countries other than the U.S. long ago revised their car regulations to account for pedestrian safety, which constrained automakers' designs.

But times are changing. In Europe, where the average new car is growing 1 centimeter wider every two years, SUVs now represent more than half of new car purchases. SUVs comprise 60 percent of new vehicle registrations in the United Kingdom, where a YouGov poll earlier this year found that 3 in 5 Brits think cars have grown too big. On the other side of the world, all of Australia's 10 bestselling models of 2023 were either SUVs or pickups. (Unlike in Europe, pickups have long had a toehold in Australia, where they're called "utes.") The story is similar among developing countries: SUVs now represent more than half of new car purchases in India and around 40 percent in China.

Some of this growth is due to shifting customer demand, particularly in countries like China, where SUVs are "perceived as symbols of wealth and status." But consumer preferences explain only part of the story.

"Automakers have a fair bit of culpability," said Colin McKerracher, an Oslo-based analyst at BloombergNEF who focuses on the transport sector. "They've spent much of the last decade advertising bigger cars, and that's because they make significantly higher profit margins on their SUVs and pickups than they do on sedans. They've told a story—'Oh, this is what customers are asking us to build'—but it's quite a coincidence that the models customers want make a higher margin."

McKerracher said that people in many countries are now experiencing a prisoner's dilemma, with carbuyers who prefer a smaller model feeling pressure to get a bigger one because of safety concerns. "There's definitely an 'arms race' element," he told me. "You don't want to be in a relatively smaller car on the road, so once other people start buying bigger vehicles, you do as well."

The spread of car bloat bodes ill for the planet, since personal vehicles already consume about a fourth of the world's oil and produce a tenth of annual carbon dioxide emissions. According to the International Energy Agency, in 2023 the growth in big cars increased oil consumption worldwide by 500,000 barrels per day and generated 20 percent of the entire global increase in manmade CO2. If SUVs were citizens of a country, the agency observed, it would rank as the fifth most polluting in the world. The rising number of vehicular behemoths also threatens decades of progress around road safety in countries like Japan and Norway, both of which recently reached postwar lows in annual crash deaths.

As in the U.S., public policy has often hastened car bloat's emergence. In Australia, imported pickups are exempt from a luxury tax that adds thousands of dollars to similarly priced sedans. In the European Union, officials repeated an American mistake by establishing automaker carbon dioxide emissions standards that scale with vehicle weight, said Dudley Curtis, spokesperson for the European Transport Safety Council. "If you had a heavier fleet, you would get an easier target," he said. "Everyone was aware of what happened in the U.S. They just thought, 'Oh, Europe is different.' "

After being caught flat-footed, some European governments are now moving to restrain car bloat through taxation. Norway and France, for instance, impose vehicle purchase charges that scale with weight and emissions, adding the equivalent of thousands of dollars to the price of an oversized car. These fees can have a major impact: In Norway, a 2023 rule applying weight-based fees to the biggest electric cars caused sales of the Hongqi, a gargantuan Chinese SUV, to collapse.

McKerracher applauds such moves. "Fuel economy rules are really, really important," he said. "You need governments to regulate average fuel economy and push automakers, because they won't improve on their own." (Note to Americans: Project 2025, the de facto playbook of the Trump administration, calls for relaxing fuel economy rules that President Joe Biden has strengthened.)

Pushback against car bloat has taken other forms, too. Safety and environmental groups are pressuring the European Union to close a backdoor channel that has enabled the importation of thousands of American pickup trucks that flunk the EU's vehicle safety rules. In India, the Centre for Public Policy Research, a think tank, has recommended that vehicles be taxed based on their physical design, particularly their width and hood height (taller hoods pose a greater threat to pedestrians).

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Advertising is also becoming a locus of regulation, especially in Europe. Edinburgh, Scotland, now refuses to advertise SUVs on city-owned property, and France plans to prohibit ads of the most polluting cars as of 2028. Last year, the U.K. banned a Toyota pickup ad for glorifying environmentally damaging behavior like driving across a riverbed.

Wariness toward large cars is especially pronounced in urban areas, where pedestrians and cyclists tend to concentrate. Earlier this year, Paris residents voted to triple the parking fees for SUVs, a move that Lyon and Tübingen have also taken. Resistance is visible at the grassroots level, too: In Brussels, activists have called for the creation of SUV-free “Low-Danger Zones” (and officials in Paris and Cardiff, Wales, have discussed implementing such restrictions). A protest group known as the Tyre Extinguishers has earned headlines and drivers’ wrath by covertly deflating the tires of parked SUVs across Europe.

Despite their recent surge in sales, oversized vehicles are not as entrenched in Europe or Asia as they are in the U.S.—at least not yet. But time is not on regulators’ side. “Part of the question is what policies you enact, but part of it is when you enact them,” said McKerracher. “It’s quite hard to claw back once big cars are the majority of the market, the way they are in North America.” If other nations want to avoid being saddled with the deadly, polluting car bloat now endemic in the U.S., they need to step on it. 🇺🇸

Sanjana Singh Raichur provided research assistance.

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